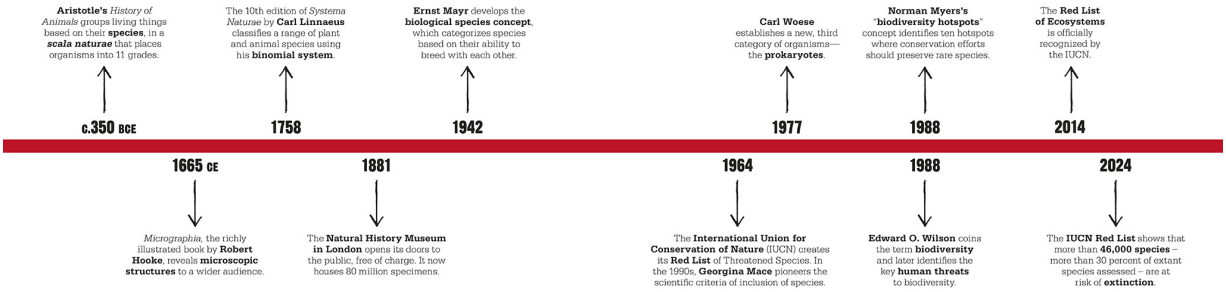
INTRODUCTION

Prehistoric cave art that dates back 30,000 years or more suggests that people have long marveled at the variety of life. In Ancient Greece in the 4th century BCE, Aristotle made an early attempt to classify living organisms; his 11-grade *scala naturae* (“ladder of life”) put humans and mammals at the top, and descended through other, more “primitive” animals to plants and then minerals. A thousand years later, the medieval world still considered variations on Aristotle’s system to be valid. There were several reasons for this. Without microscopes, nothing was known of microorganisms and cells. Without the means to explore underwater, science’s knowledge of aquatic creatures was limited, and many parts of the world were still unknown to Western scientists. In keeping with the prevailing ideas of the Catholic Church, the natural world was seen as static and unchanging.



Read accessible description

An age of discovery

The age of expeditions of discovery revealed regions, animals, and plants formerly unknown to Western science. In *History of the Animals* (1551–58), Swiss physician and naturalist Conrad Gesner included some of the recent finds from the New World and the Far East, as well as relying on classical literature. The five-volume work reflected his division of animals into